

What Remains of Edith Finch Story and Gameplay analysis

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In What Remains of Edith Finch, I feel the story and the gameplay are really tied together, because each chapter uses a different style that fits this chapter's character to show one's death. The main thing you do is explore the Finch house, and each room feels like a small museum, so just moving and looking around tells you a person's characteristics.

When you read a story for one family member, the game usually changes the mechanics in a special way for that chapter, so you experience it with your hands. For example, for Lewis, you do the same chopping motion again and again, but at the same time you control a fantasy world in your head. The more you play, the fantasy part becomes bigger and more important, and the real work becomes background. This mechanic makes you feel how he escapes reality and slowly disconnects from real life. For Gregory, you are in a baby's perspective, and you play with bath toys. The playful mechanic makes the tragedy hit harder. For Calvin, you swing higher and higher, like you are chasing a bigger feeling. It shows how a small action becomes something unstoppable. I liked Barbara's chapter the most, because this chapter uses a "horror comic" style to tell her story, and the gameplay matches that feeling. The comic style makes actions feel like performance. The dramatic narrator makes simple actions (walking, opening a door) feel like a scene in a show. That supports the idea that Barbara is remembered as a child star.

Even though the player is pressing buttons and making actions happen, the player still cannot change the outcome, so it reminds the player again that this game is about witnessing and understanding, not saving anyone. So the mechanics convey the theme by limiting your control and by using different mini-game styles to show how each person saw the world, which makes the story feel more emotional.